

Current Debates in Economics

Term, *Year*, Instructor: Gagandeep Sachdeva

Tentative Reading List

Unit 1: Justice and Equity

- ☐ Notions of justice and equity, and how economists think (and differ) on them.
 - ☐ Amartya Sen's [The Idea of Justice](#) (Selected Chapters)
 - ☐ Michael Sandel's [Justice: what is the right thing to do](#) (Selected chapters- though honestly the whole book is a great read)
 - ☐ [Dani Rodrik's weblog: The Economics Debate, again and again](#)

Unit 2: Inequality and Growth, Introducing the Tradeoff

- ☐ Inequality
 - ☐ [Long-Run Trends in the Distribution of Income and Wealth - ScienceDirect](#)
 - ☐ [Changes in the Wage Structure and Earnings Inequality - ScienceDirect](#)
 - ☐ [New ways of looking at old issues: inequality and growth - ScienceDirect](#) (introduction only)
 - ☐ [Income inequality in the developing world | Science](#)
 - ☐ Do we only care about inequality in the context of its relationship with growth?
 - ☐ [Occupy Wall Street and the Political Economy of Inequality](#)
- ☐ Equality/Equity vs Efficiency: Is There a Tradeoff at all?
 - ☐ Theoretical basis for the existence of a tradeoff.
 - ☐ Empirical evidence (or lack thereof) for the existence of a tradeoff.
 - ☐ Contextual differences and unintended consequences
 - ☐ [The Case of the Red-Cockaded Woodpecker](#)
 - ☐ [The problem with "ban the box"](#)
 - ☐ [Dani Rodrik's weblog: Why do economists disagree?](#)

Unit 3: Specific Topics:

- ☐ Education: Standardized Testing
 - ☐ [Standardized Test Scores and Academic Performance at Ivy-Plus Colleges](#)
 - ☐ [Standardized tests aren't biased, says new data—but scores reflect society's biases | GBH](#)
 - ☐ [The Racist Beginnings of Standardized Testing | NEA](#)
 - ☐ [Uncovering Implicit Bias in Assessment, Feedback and Grading | All Things Assessment](#)
- ☐ Labor Relations and Workers' Rights 1: Minimum wages and unemployment
 - ☐ Classical view: equity vs efficiency (Slides)
 - ☐ Survey of empirical evidence/policy debates: [Separating signal from noise: a review of 12 major studies on minimum wages and poverty – Arindrajit Dube](#)
 - ☐ [Casual versus Causal Inference: Time series edition – Arindrajit Dube](#)
 - ☐ [\\$15 Minimum Wage - Clark Center Forum](#), [Minimum Wage - Clark Center Forum](#)

- ☐ Labor Relations and Workers' Rights 1: The role of unions
 - ☐ Classical view: equity vs efficiency
 - ☐ Survey of empirical evidence/policy debates.
 - ☐ [Labor Unions - Clark Center Forum](#)
- ☐ Labor Relations and Workers' Rights 3: Immigration
 - ☐  The debate over immigration and wages, explained (a demonstration of how a political debate became a very scientific one).
 - ☐ Classical view: equity vs efficiency
 - ☐ [Low-Skilled Immigrants - Clark Center Forum](#)
 - ☐ [High-Skilled Immigrants - Clark Center Forum](#)
 - ☐ [Refugees in Germany - Clark Center Forum](#)
- ☐ Discrimination:
 - ☐ Theories and critiques of theories (Slides)
 - ☐ [An Open Letter to Economists from Bill Spriggs](#)
 - ☐ [A Constructivist Perspective on Empirical Discrimination Research](#) (Introduction Only)
 - ☐ Gender: Wage Gap
 - ☐ [Claudia Goldin: The Quiet Revolution That Transformed Women's Employment, Education, and Family](#)
 - ☐ [Marianne Bertrand: New Perspectives on Gender](#)
 - ☐ [Ask Gap in Wages, How the salary 'ask gap' perpetuates unequal pay](#)
 - ☐ Race: Algorithmic Bias
 - ☐ [Machine Bias — ProPublica](#)
 - ☐ [Inherent Trade-Offs in the Fair Determination of Risk Scores](#) (Introduction only)
 - ☐ [Exploration-based algorithms can improve hiring quality and diversity | MIT Sloan](#)
 - ☐ Race: Affirmative Action in Admissions
 - ☐ [What Students Are Saying About the End of Race-Based Affirmative Action in College Admissions - The New York Times](#)
 - ☐ [Affirmative action, meritocracy, and efficiency](#) (introduction only)
- ☐ Environment/Climate Justice
 - ☐ Basic theoretical foundations: externalities, common pool resources (slides)
 - ☐ [How economists see the environment | Nature](#)
 - ☐ [A typology of loss and damage perspectives | Nature Climate Change](#)
 - ☐ [It is unfair to push poor countries to reach zero carbon emissions too early](#)